

ONLINE GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE AGAINST WOMEN MEDIA WORKERS:

A REVIEW FOR POLICY ACTION

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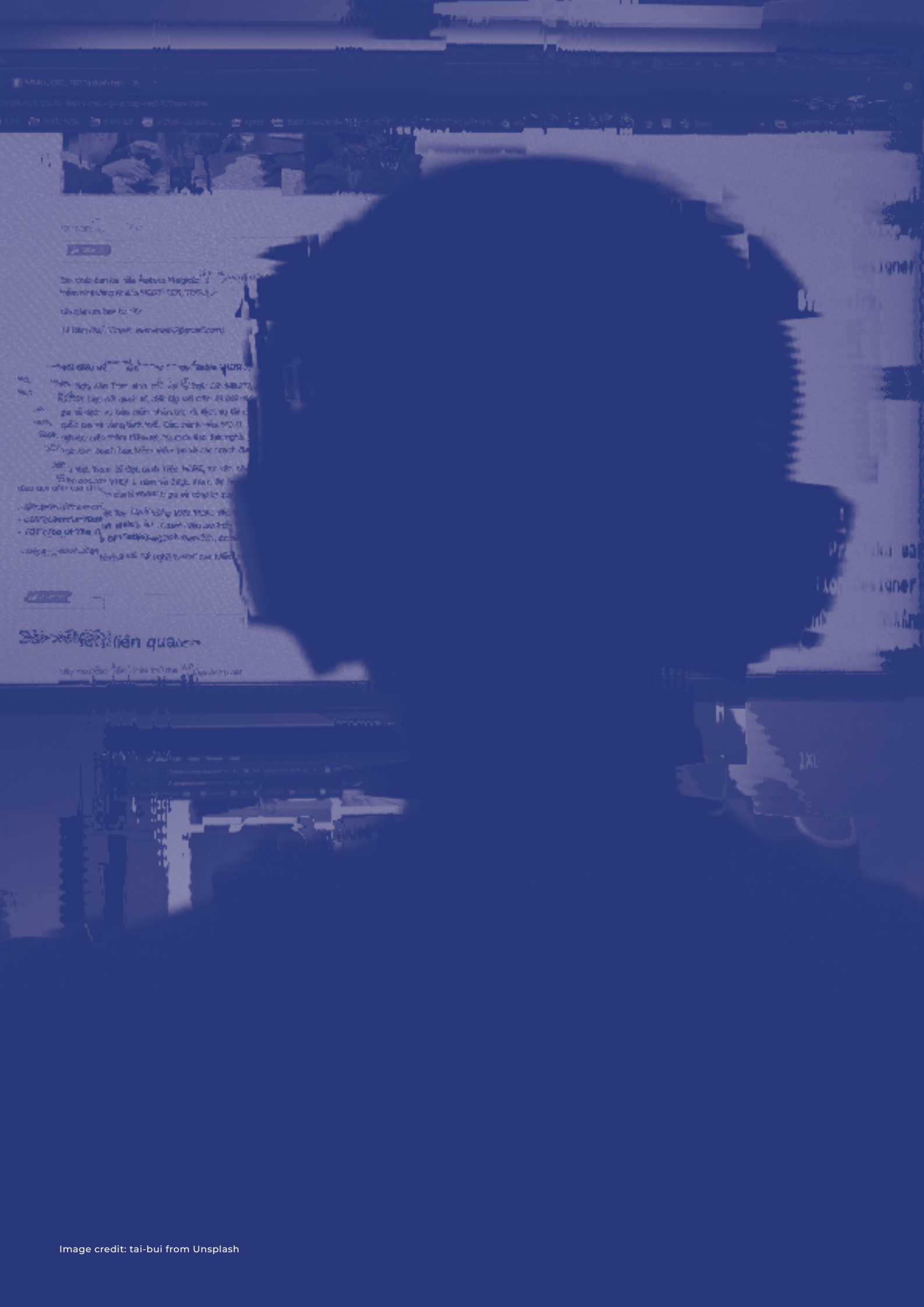


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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Online harassment, abuse and violence against women working in the media[1] is an internationally recognised problem. A landmark 2022 study from UNESCO and the International Center for Journalists (ICFJ) found that online violence directed towards women journalists was a pervasive, global and under-resourced issue that threatened democracy, press freedom and the participation of women in the public sphere.[2] The report identifies organisational support as critical to ensure primary responsibility for dealing with online abuse does not rest on individuals as this risks normalising online violence.[3] Yet media organisations appear reluctant to take up the call to offer meaningful support and integrate policy changes that protect journalists—the UN reported this year that online violence against women journalists is getting worse.[4]

This report examines over 25 publicly available institutional policies, guidelines and relevant documents from 8 of the biggest Australian media organisations that relate to online gender-based violence. The review findings reveal a significant and consistent absence of gender-responsive and intersectional frameworks across organisational policies, staff codes of conduct, and online community guidelines. Addressing this gap is necessary to create environments in which women working in media can participate safely, freely, and on equal terms, contributing to a healthy and representative democracy.

This review highlights how some organisations are performing better than others in addressing gendered online violence. Strong organisational policies are presented through case studies alongside examples of where policy and practice could be improved. The report concludes with four key recommendations:

1. Transition to gender-responsive and intersectional policy frameworks to account for and address the uneven distribution of violence across newsrooms and in media organisations.
2. Develop an organisational approach to online abuse against women media workers by implementing training across all levels of the organisation, not just for public-facing workers to redistribute responsibility for preventing online gendered violence.
3. Establish clear and consistent policy standards on online violence against women media workers to clarify expectations of staff and audiences.
4. Enforce and advocate for stronger online safety protections for women working in media to protect workers and create a better digital environment for everyone who engages in the digital world.

This report is an open invitation to media organisations in Australia to make online environments safer for women and join a growing movement of civil society organisations advocating for a better digital future for everyone.

In this report, we refer to women media workers, not only journalists, to recognise the diversity of people who are experiencing gendered online abuse in the course of doing their work and to account for the increased casualisation of work in the media sector. Editors, journalists, professional staff, and content creators for media outlets can experience online gender-based violence in a multitude of ways.

1 Throughout this report, the terms 'gender-based online violence', 'online abuse', 'online violence', 'online harassment' and 'online misogyny' are used interchangeably to denote digital harassment, threats, and violence directed at women because of their gender, facilitated through information and communication technologies (ICT).

2 Posetti et al. *The Chilling: A global study of online violence against women journalists*, 2022.

3 Ibid

4 UN Women, *'The goal is silence': Women journalists report increasing violence online*, 2026, https://www.unwomen.org/en/news-stories/feature-story/2026/05/the-goal-is-silence-women-journalists-report-increasing-violence-online

INTRODUCTION

Online gender-based violence refers to digital harassment, threats, and violence directed at women because of their gender, or because of how their gender intersects with race, religion, sexual orientation, cultural background, or disability[5]. These behaviours are committed, assisted, or aggravated using information and communication technologies (ICT), including social media platforms, messaging applications, emails, and online forums[6]. This form of violence includes sexual harassment, rape threats, threats of physical harm against women or their families, doxing, trolling, and appearance-based attacks[7]. Online harassment also works through accumulation, where many minor comments together create targeted abuse[8]. Significantly, online gender-based violence against women media workers is not confined to digital spaces; it extends into offline environments, including workplaces, creating compounded harm for victims[9].

Women with an online presence experience high levels of online abuse targeting their gender and other aspects of their identity. According to the eSafety Commissioner's *Women in the Spotlight: Women's Experiences with Online Abuse in Their Working Lives* report[10], 1 in 3 women in Australia has experienced online abuse in the context of their work. Online abuse targeting women varies significantly by visibility: 56% of women with a media presence experience online abuse, compared with 47% of those with an online presence only and 25% of women without a current media or online presence[11].

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Critically, media workers from minoritised and marginalised communities, including Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander women, women from culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) backgrounds, women with disabilities, LGBTQIA+ women and gender-diverse people and young women experience disproportionately high abuse rates[12] [13] [14]. Research on the *Online Safety of Diverse Journalists in Australia*[15] documented high rates of online harassment among diverse journalists overall. While the study examined journalists across genders, the patterns documented—with 28.3% experiencing harassment 'several times a year', 19.6% 'about once a month,' alongside accumulative abusive

5 Media Diversity Australia, *Online Safety of Diverse Journalists*, 2023, https://www.mediadiversityaustralia.org/online-safety-of-diverse-journalists
6 UN Women, *Online and ICT-Facilitated Violence Against Women and Girls During COVID-19*, 2020, https://www.unwomen.org/en/digital-library/publications/2020/04/brief-online-and-ict-facilitated-violence-against-women-and-girls-during-covid-19
7 eSafety Commissioner, *Supporting Journalists to Engage Safely Online*, Australian Government, 2025, https://www.esafety.gov.au/educators/community-education/supporting-journalists-engage-safely-online
8 Media Diversity Australia, *Online Safety of Diverse Journalists*, 2023
9 eSafety Commissioner, *Supporting Journalists to Engage Safely Online*, Australian Government, 2025
10 eSafety Commissioner, 2022, https://www.esafety.gov.au/research/how-online-abuse-impacts-women-working-lives
11 Ibid
12 Media Diversity Australia, *Online Safety of Diverse Journalists*, 2023
13 eSafety Commissioner, *Supporting Journalists to Engage Safely Online*, 2025
14 Intersection Pty Ltd, *Out in the Open: Changing the Culture at Nine Entertainment,* 2024
15 Media Diversity Australia, Page, 28-29, 2023

messaging[16]—align with broader findings[17] on gendered online abuse against women journalists. Furthermore, support structures for affected journalists proved inadequate. Journalists predominantly relied on informal networks including friends (76.1%), family and colleagues (56.6%) rather than accessing institutional support from employers (26.1%) or unions/peak bodies (6.5%). The normalisation of online abuse presents media workplaces with an urgent need and opportunity to implement protective interventions[18] [19].

There is strong national and international evidence showing that online harassment targeting women with a high public profile leads to self-censorship, as it is deliberately designed to silence them[20] [21] [22] [23] . Online abuse is forcing women working in media to withdraw from covering certain topics or to leave the profession entirely—representing not only a significant professional setback, but a direct threat to balanced and diverse news reporting. Online gender-based violence has a direct impact on press freedom, freedom of expression, and the public's right to access diverse information[24] [25] [26] [27] [28]. For women media workers from minoritised and marginalised communities, the impact is particularly pronounced, operating as a mechanism of exclusion from digital public spheres[29] [30] .

Taken together, it becomes clear that online gender-based violence directly undermines women's rights—not only their right to live free from violence, but also their ability to participate fully in the public sphere. The resulting pressure to lower their online profiles poses a serious threat to democracy, as well as limiting women's broader contributions to their professions, organisations, and society.

The personal toll is equally significant. According to eSafety Commissioner research, women who experience online abuse report serious negative impacts on their mental health and personal confidence[31]. The research also indicates that many women can avoid leadership roles and limit their career progression as a result of experiencing online violence[32]. These consequences compound the broader social and democratic costs of gendered online violence. The research also highlights how the repercussions extend beyond the individual, affecting employers, innovation, the economy, and the integrity of democratic participation itself[33].

There is an urgent need for targeted, gender-sensitive workplace policy in Australian media organisations. Organisations need policies, guidelines, and codes of conduct that explicitly recognise and address the risks and lived experience of gendered online violence in the workplace. These measures are not merely good practice, they are a democratic, legal and ethical imperative.

16 Ibid
17 eSafety Commissioner, *Supporting Journalists to Engage Safely Online*, 2025
18 eSafety Commissioner, *Women in the Spotlight: Women's Experiences with Online Abuse in Their Working Lives*, 2022
19 Media Diversity Australia, *Online Safety of Diverse Journalists*, 2023
20 UN Women and European Commission, *Tipping Point: The Chilling Escalation of Online Violence Against Women in the Public Sphere*, 2025, https://unwomen.org.au/seven-in-ten-women-human-rights-defenders-activists-and-journalists-report-online-violence/
21 Amnesty International Argentina, *Muteadas: El Impacto de la Violencia Digital Contra las Periodistas* [*Muted: The Impact of Digital Violence Against Women Journalists*], 2024, https://globalfreedomofexpression.columbia.edu/updates/2024/10/informe-de-amnistia-internacional-argentina-muteadas-el-impacto-de-la-violencia-digital-contra-las-periodistas/
22 eSafety Commissioner, *Women in the Spotlight*: Women's Experiences with Online Abuse in Their Working Lives, 2022
23 IPS Journal, *Online Abuse Could Drive Women Out of Politics*, 2024, https://www.ips-journal.eu/topics/democracy-and-society/online-abuse-could-drive-women-out-of-politics-7036/
24 RSF, *Sexism's Toll on Journalism*, 2020
25 eSafety Commissioner, *Supporting Journalists to Engage Safely Online*, 2025
26 UN Women and European Commission, *Tipping Point: The Chilling Escalation of Online Violence Against Women in the Public Sphere*, 2025
27 Amnesty International Argentina, *Muteadas: El Impacto de la Violencia Digital Contra las Periodistas* [*Muted: The Impact of Digital Violence Against Women Journalists*], 2024
28 Media Diversity Australia, *Online Safety of Diverse Journalists*, 2023
29 Ibid
30 eSafety Commissioner, *Supporting Journalists to Engage Safely Online*, 2025
31 eSafety Commissioner, *Women in the Spotlight: Women's Experiences with Online Abuse in Their Working Lives*, 2022
32 Ibid
33 Ibid

1. REVIEW OF AUSTRALIAN MEDIA ORGANISATIONS



The review focused on eight Australian media outlets: two public broadcasters (ABC, SBS), three commercial TV networks (Channels 7, 9, 10), and three digital news platforms (The Guardian Australia, News.com.au, and Sky News Australia—now called News24) (see Fig.1).

Despite the extensive literature demonstrating that online violence disproportionately affects women media workers, the **review shows that many of the most popular Australian media outlets lack policies that explicitly address gendered violence or misogyny targeting women.** Gender-neutral[34] policies render invisible how online violence impacts some groups more than others. Further, with the exception of a small number of media organisations, such as SBS's *Appropriate Workplace Behaviour Policy*[35], News.com.au's *Equality in Employment and Anti-Harassment Policy*[36] and *Misconduct Policy*[37], few outlets have publicly available policies specifically focused on addressing harassment.

Selection criteria

The media outlets were chosen based on several criteria:

1. Market prominence and national reach.
2. Representation across diverse media formats and ownership model, focusing on public broadcast (TV/radio), commercial broadcast TV networks and digital news platforms.
3. Active social media presence.
4. Operation within Australian legal and regulatory frameworks.
5. Accessibility of policies for analysis.

This selection enables comparative analysis of organisational responses to online abuse against women media workers across different ownership models and media types.

34 'Gender-neutral' refers to the acknowledgement of gender in policies without differentiating between groups or recognising the distinct experiences and risks associated with different gender identities.

35 Special Broadcasting Service (SBS), 2025, https://www.sbs.com.au/aboutus/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/20.-Appropriate-Workplace-Behaviour-Policy.pdf

36 News Corp Australia, 2024, https://www.newscorpaustralia.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/Equality-in-Employment-and-Anti-Harassment-Policy.pdf

37 News Corp Australia, 2024, https://www.newscorpaustralia.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/Misconduct-Policy.pdf

MEDIA OUTLETS	FORMAT/ OWNERSHIP MODEL	INSTITUTIONAL POLICIES, GUIDELINES, RELEVANT DOCUMENTS REVIEWED
SBS	Public Broadcast (TV/radio)	- SBS Social Media Protocol - SBS codes of practice - SBS Appropriate Workplace Behaviour Policy - SBS Facebook - SBS Terms and conditions - SBS Submission to The Department of Infrastructure, Transport, Regional Development and Communications. Consultation on a bill for a new online safety act Feb 2021
ABC	Public Broadcast (TV/radio)	- ABC Submission 65 to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society June 2024 - Section Work health and safety in the ABC Annual Report 2023–24 - ABC Editorial policies: Harm and offence - ABC Facebook Community Guidelines - ABC Terms of Use - ABC House Rules and Meta Community Standards
Channel 9	Commercial TV network	- Nine Code of Conduct - Nine Diversity and Inclusion - 9 News Facebook Community Guidelines - Report Out in the Open: Changing the Culture at Nine Entertainment: Independent Review of the Nine Entertainment Corporation 2024 - Nine's Action Plan to implement the recommendations of the Independent External Review Out in the Open: Changing the Culture at Nine Entertainment - Your Call resource
Channel 7	Commercial TV network	- Editorial Policy - Legal Policies and Guidelines
Channel 10	Commercial TV network	- Terms of Use - Social Media Community Guidelines
The Guardian	Digital news platform	- Community standards and participation guidelines
news.com.au	Digital news platform	- Equality in Employment and Anti-Harassment Policy - Commenting Guidelines - Misconduct Policy
News24 (formerly Sky News)	Digital news platform	- Commenting Guidelines

Fig.1 Australian media outlets

2. SUMMARY OF FINDINGS ACROSS MEDIA ORGANISATIONS

1. Systematic lack of specific gender-based policy frameworks for women media workers across media documents.

Most of the organisational policies reviewed for this report predominantly employ gender-neutral frameworks when addressing abusive online content and staff conduct. These frameworks fail to explicitly acknowledge or address the online gendered violence and misogyny disproportionately experienced by women working in media organisations. The systematic absence of gender-responsive policy targeting women working in media has remained largely unchanged over years, despite increasing evidence of escalating online violence against women in journalism[38] [39].

2. Systematic lack of intersectional perspectives in policies.

The majority of media organisations examined in this report merely list multiple protected characteristics, such as race, age, nationality, and religion, which do not constitute a genuinely intersectional approach. The exception is ABC, which acknowledges that online violence disproportionately affects women media workers with multiple marginalised identities[40] (see Case Study 1). Media organisations mainly apply an additive framework that acknowledges various grounds for discrimination separately, without recognising how these characteristics overlap and compound harm.

3. Social media moderation guidelines across most outlets rely on general measures to remove or block abusive content but vary in specificity.

While some organisations, such as The Guardian's *Community Standards and Participation Guidelines*[41] explicitly name discrimination based on gender, sex, or sexual orientation, others—including the ABC's *Moderation Guidelines* included on its *Terms of Use* policy[42] and Channel 9's *Facebook Community Guidelines*—use broad terms such as 'offensive' or 'abusive' without explicitly addressing or mentioning gender in their documents. In the case of the ABC, this reveals a gender fragmented policy landscape, where public acknowledgement of the disproportionate impact of online violence on female journalists[43] is not consistently reflected in moderation guidelines.

4. Lack of systemic movement.

Despite various media policy recommendations to improve the situation for women media workers facing online violence, generally there has been very little systemic progress in translating these initiatives into formal policies and guidelines. The ABC's appointment of a dedicated Social Media Wellbeing Advisor[44] represents a notable institutional response (see Case Study 1).

38 UN Women and European Commission, *Tipping Point: The Chilling Escalation of Online Violence Against Women in the Public Sphere*, 2025

39 Amnesty International Argentina, *Muteadas: El Impacto de la Violencia Digital Contra las Periodistas* [*Muted: The Impact of Digital Violence Against Women Journalists*], 2024

40 Australian Broadcasting Corporation (ABC), *Submission to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society*, 2024, https://www.abc.net.au/about/plans-reports-and-submissions/submissions/abc-submission-to-the-joint-select-committee-on-social-media-and/104135960

41 The Guardian, 2009, https://www.theguardian.com/community-standards

42 ABC, n.d., https://help.abc.net.au/hc/en-us/articles/360001548096-ABC-Terms-of-Use

43 ABC, *Submission to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society*, 2024

44 ABC, *Fighting Back Against Online Gender-Based Violence*, 2025, https://www.abc.net.au/abc-international-development/250321-fighting-back-against-online-gbv/105081434

5. Systematic focus on regulation over protection.

Existing internal regulations such as news.com.au's *Equality in Employment and Anti-Harassment Policy*[45], seem to prioritise behavioural compliance by specifying what staff must or must not do, rather than equipping journalists with training to recognise abuse and harassment and to respond effectively when they experience it. Again, the ABC represents a partial exception through the introduction of the Social Media Wellbeing Advisor[46] [47] and the best practices newsroom guidance, grounded on its collaboration with the eSafety Commissioner[48] (see Case Study 1). Additionally, enforcement mechanisms—particularly within the organisations' social media guidelines and protocols—are rarely specified in the publicly available documents reviewed.



6. Inconsistent and often ambiguous use of 'sex' and 'gender' terminology across media policies and guidelines.

It is unclear whether these distinctions are the result of deliberate policy choices; however, the selection of one term over the other carries concrete regulatory, ethical, and representational implications for how harm is recognised and addressed. For example, The Guardian's *Community Standards and Participation Guidelines*[49] refers explicitly to both concepts sex and gender identity when moderating online content while Channel 7's *Legal Policies* and *Community Rules*[50] refer more generally to gender.

7. Systematic lack of clarity regarding whether media organisations encourage journalists to respond to abusive comments.

Most guidelines remain vague about media workers' moderation roles, with the exception of The Guardian[51], which explicitly states that authors cannot moderate comments themselves. This lack of clarity creates a significant gap in guidance and has implications for women media workers' agency in responding to online violence. As highlighted by the ICFJ's report T*he Chilling: A Global Study on Online Violence Against Women Journalists*[52], restrictive social media rules, such as advising journalists to remain respectful in the face of abuse or avoid engagement, can undermine women's agency and contribute to feelings of powerlessness, potentially exacerbating the mental health impacts of online violence.

45 News Corp Australia, *Equality in Employment and Anti-Harassment Policy*, 2024, https://www.newscorpaustralia.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/Equality-in-Employment-and-Anti-Harassment-Policy.pdf

46 ABC, *Submission to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society*, 2024

47 ABC, *Fighting Back Against Online Gender-Based Violence*, 2025

48 eSafety Commissioner, *Online Safety Tips for Journalists*, Australian Government, 2025, https://www.esafety.gov.au/educators/community-education/supporting-journalists-engage-safely-online/tips-for-journalists

49 The Guardian, 2009

50 Seven Network, Community Rules, n.d., https://support.7plus.com.au/hc/en-au/articles/4403065130765-Community-Rules

51 The Guardian, Community FAQs, 2009, https://www.theguardian.com/community-faqs

52 International Center for Journalists (ICFJ), 2022., https://www.icfj.org/our-work/chilling-global-study-online-violence-against-women-journalists

3. CASE STUDIES OF BEST PRACTICES IN AUSTRALIAN MEDIA OUTLETS



CASE STUDY 1

ABC institutional accountability and intersectionality

ABC exemplifies institutional accountability for online abuse affecting journalists through a dedicated Social Media Wellbeing Advisor role[53] [54], established in 2020. The advisor provides comprehensive support to staff experiencing online harassment, including psychological resources, security measures, and reporting guidance while also implementing preventive strategies through risk assessment at content commissioning. ABC's dual approach, which supports those harmed while preventing future abuse, is strengthened by the advisor's collaboration with the eSafety Commissioner in developing an *Online Safety Tips for Journalists* best practice guide[55]. The guide provides practical training for journalists and managers on handling online exposure, responding to abuse, accessing support, and supporting colleagues addressing the full spectrum of online abuse experiences. However, while comprehensive, the guide adopts a gender-neutral approach and does not explicitly address the experiences or risks faced by women.

ABC also demonstrates a level of awareness of intersectional awareness through its public recognition[56] that online violence disproportionately affects journalists with multiple marginalised identities, including women, CALD, LGBTQIA+, Indigenous, and disabled journalists, acknowledging that gender intersects with race, age, nationality, and religion to intensify harm. This intersectional approach, while remaining implicit rather than explicitly codified in organisational policy, represents a critical departure from institutional practice across the media sector. Whereas most organisations examined in this report enumerate protected characteristics without analysing their intersecting effects, the ABC's approach acknowledges the compounded vulnerability of multiply marginalised journalists, advancing understanding of how structural inequalities operate through online abuse.

53 ABC, *Submission to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society*, 2024
54 ABC, *Fighting Back Against Online Gender-Based Violence*, 2025
55 eSafety Commissioner, 2025
56 ABC, *Submission to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society*, 2024

CASE STUDY 2

SBS institutional responsibility and proactive intervention

SBS's *Appropriate Workplace Behaviour Policy*[57] provides a comprehensive framework for addressing harassment by defining sex-based harassment as 'sexist or misogynist' conduct and thereby recognising the gendered nature of such conduct. The policy covers both offline and online spaces and aligns with the *Sex Discrimination Act 1984 (Cth)*. The policy establishes robust internal accountability mechanisms via the *Staff Complaint Procedure*. The procedure outlines clear managerial responsibilities: managers must prevent or respond to breaches and intervene when unacceptable behaviour occurs, regardless of whether a formal complaint has been filed. However, while the policy addresses gendered forms of harassment, its gender-neutral institutional framing does not explicitly acknowledge that harassment disproportionately affects women nor does it address the intersectional dimensions of workplace misconduct.

57 SBS, 2025

CASE STUDY 3

The Guardian and SBS content moderation and editorial responsibility

The Guardian and SBS exemplify institutional accountability through proactive content moderation. In the Guardian's model, stated in its *Community Standards and Participation Guidelines*[58], effectiveness derives from two integrated elements: enabling readers and journalists to report community standard violations and ensuring rapid moderator enforcement to minimise harm from abusive posts.

SBS's approach establishes clear editorial control through defined *Terms and Conditions*[59], permitting removal of abusive, offensive, threatening, harassing, obscene, bullying, provocative, inappropriate, off-topic, repetitive, or rule-breaking content.

Although applying a gender-neutral approach, both media organisations recognise that moderation is not merely a reactive tool but a harm-reduction strategy integral to institutional responsibility for journalist safety and platform community standards.

58 The Guardian, 2009, https://www.theguardian.com/community-standards
59 SBS, n.d., https://www.sbs.com.au/aboutus/terms-and-conditions/

CASE STUDY 4

Channel 9 external intermediary reporting as institutional accountability

Your Call[60] is an independent, 24/7 external intermediary service appointed by Nine to provide confidential reporting mechanisms for all staff experiencing or witnessing sexual harassment or inappropriate conduct. The service operates through multiple channels (written and phone) and offers staff choice between anonymous or identified reporting. Key features include: employees retain control over the reporting process, including choices about investigator gender and information access restrictions; information is shared only with designated Nine team members, with anonymity maintained where requested; and staff can choose between informal and formal resolution pathways, with ongoing support throughout the process. This model demonstrates institutional accountability through external oversight while maintaining staff choice and confidentiality.

60 Nine Entertainment, *Your Call*, n.d., https://nine.relyplatform.com/f/9LDS4LQ

4. RECOMMENDATIONS

Recommendation 1: Transition to gender-responsive and intersectional policy frameworks

1.1 Gender-responsive policy design to address online harm

Media organisations should urgently transition from gender-neutral frameworks, which obscure who is most affected by online violence, to gender-responsive policies that:

- Apply gendered language consistency across all policies and procedures.
- Explicitly recognise the disproportionate violence experienced by women.
- Enable targeted, evidence-based interventions funded on a gendered approach by recognising that women's experiences differ from generic approaches and designing solutions accordingly (for practical approach see Recommendation 2).

1.2 Intersectional approach

Policy frameworks must incorporate an intersectional perspective, examining how gender interacts with race, age, sexual identity, nationality, and religion to compound vulnerability to and experiences of online violence. This approach recognises that women media workers' experiences of online violence are shaped by overlapping systems of oppression and marginalisation, and that effective policy must reflect this complexity to be most effective.

Gender-responsive and intersectional policy frameworks should be embedded within a comprehensive organisational strategy supported by four action plans

- Gender equality action plan
- Disability inclusion action plan
- Multicultural and diversity inclusion action plan
- Reconciliation Action Plan

The strategy must include measurable targets and outcomes, with all supporting plans subject to regular review and updates.

Recommendation 2: Develop an organisational approach to online abuse against women media workers

Create, review and update policies and procedures to ensure they reflect a best practice approach grounded in an organisation's positive duty to actively protect women media workers. Organisations should ensure their policies provide adequate tools, training, and support needed to prevent, recognise, respond to, and recover from online violence.

Specifically, organisations should:

- Introduce mandatory training for senior leadership and managers as a priority on preventing, identifying and responding to online harassment, modelled on initiatives such as the ABC's Social Media Wellbeing Advisor[61] [62].
- Ensure all training frames gendered online violence against media workers within the broader context of women's rights, including digital rights, press freedom, freedom of expression, and the public's right to access diverse information.
- Establish dedicated internal reporting systems and support mechanisms informed by the *Online Safety Tips for Journalists*[63] and grounded in a person-centred approach for safety and wellbeing, including access to wellbeing advisors, legal guidance, and reporting pathways, for those who experience or witness online violence.
- Conduct regular reviews and updates of internal policies incorporating workers' perspectives and feedback to ensure they reflect the lived experiences of those most at risk, adopting an intersectional perspective that gives particular attention to journalists who are CALD, LGBTQIA+, Indigenous, and/or living with disability.
- Conduct regular monitoring and evaluation of the above measures to assess their effectiveness and identify areas for improvement. Organisations should provide annual public reporting on training completion rates, disaggregated by gender, role, and outcome measures (e.g., women's sense of safety).
- Independent bodies such as the Media, Entertainment and Arts Alliance should audit compliance and publicly track which media organisations meet obligations.

61 ABC, *Submission to the Joint Select Committee on Social Media and Australian Society*, 2024
62 ABC, *Fighting Back Against Online Gender-Based Violence*, 2025
63 eSafety Commissioner, 2025

Recommendation 3: Establish clear and consistent policy standards on online violence against women media workers

Review and update all policies and guidelines related to workplace behaviour, including employment and anti-harassment policies, appropriate workplace behaviour policies, equality in employment policies, misconduct policies, commenting guidelines, social media guidelines and protocols, and community moderation approaches, to establish clear, consistent standards and expectations regarding online harm faced by women media workers, in accordance with positive duty obligations.

This includes strengthening behavioural standards across all relevant documents by:

- Providing clear definitions and explanations of what constitutes abuse, sexual harassment, sex-based harassment, and inappropriate workplace behaviour on the grounds of sex and gender, using a gendered perspective. This should also address the systemic drivers of harassment and abuse, including the structural power dynamics that enable their existence.
- Explicitly include remote work and online spaces within the definition of 'workplace' across all relevant documents.
- Establishing a clear organisational position on whether staff should respond to abusive comments on organisation-owned social media accounts, developed in consultation with workers to ensure it reflects their experiences.
- Implementing institutional accountability frameworks that take responsibility for violence occurring in digital workplaces, including personal social media accounts, as well as offline abuse, harassment and violence.

Recommendation 4: Enforce and advocate for stronger online safety protections for women working in media

- Clearly articulate enforcement mechanisms and guidelines regarding online harm against women across all relevant documents—including internal conduct policies, standards for user interaction, and content governance across digital platforms.
- Enforcement measures should include clear and accessible referral pathways and resources or support when workers need to make complaints.
- Media organisations and workers should advocate for an enforceable Digital Duty of Care that puts the onus on to social media companies and other online platforms to create spaces that are safer for everyone.

CONCLUSION



This report reveals a critical gap: despite overwhelming evidence that online gender-based violence disproportionately affects women media workers, most Australian media organisations lack gendered-responsive and intersectional policy frameworks to address this threat. Gender-neutral policies render invisible women's distinct experiences of online misogyny, and progress in translating policy recommendations into institutional change has been minimal.

However, the case studies demonstrate that change is possible. The ABC's Social Media Wellbeing Advisor and public acknowledgement of intersectional harm, SBS's gendered harassment policy with proactive intervention stated in its *Appropriate Workplace Behaviour Policy*, Nine's Your Call reporting service, and The Guardian's and SBS's rapid content moderation and editorial responsibility show that organisations can act.

The four recommendations in this report provide a clear pathway:

1. Adopt gendered and intersectional policy frameworks.
2. Develop comprehensive institutional approaches to online gender-based violence.
3. Establish consistent standards across all policies.
4. Enforce protections while advocating for stronger digital safety mechanisms.

Media organisations have the evidence, the models, and the frameworks they need. What remains is institutional will. By prioritising women journalists' safety and digital rights grounded in the experiences of those most affected, Australian media organisations can create workplaces where women can participate safely, freely, and on equal terms in their workplaces and the public sphere. This is not aspirational; it is achievable and necessary for democratic participation.

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